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Research Proposal

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Background of Topic

Despite the United Kingdom in the twenty-first century operating as a robust constitutional monarchy and parliamentary democracy, underpinned by three distinct yet overlapping branches of power: the executive, the legislature, and the judiciary and a system of fused powers, where the executive is drawn directly from, and held accountable by, the legislature, our trade unions still lack the necessary make-up to politicise their responsibility as valued organisations with inherent power in the political process. While this contradiction can create institutional tensions, constitutional checks and balances maintain systemic equilibrium. Within this framework, statutory laws are enforced by territorial and regional police forces who retain a different form of power. The legislative process relies on a bicameral parliament: the elected House of Commons debates and votes on legislation through rigorous adversarial stages, while the unelected House of Lords serves as a vital revising chamber to scrutinise and amend proposed bills. The constitutional monarch performs essential ceremonial roles, delivering the King's Speech to outline the government's legislative agenda and granting Royal Assent as the final formal ratification of an Act of Parliament.

Public value theory (Moore, 1995) and Neo-Weberian State theory offer critical frameworks for analysing how these traditional structures navigate modern governance. Neo-Weberian theory emphasizes the enduring legitimacy and modernization of state bureaucracy, reinforcing representative democracy while adapting administrative processes to be more citizen-orientated. Conversely, Public value theory focuses on public sector innovation, encouraging administrative leaders to look beyond strict bureaucratic compliance to actively co-create societal value with citizens. Together, these theories demonstrate that rather than sitting tentatively on the fringes of power, the UK's democratic institutions retain their institutional survival by continually evolving to preserve social order and public trust.

Introductory Overview

I have written a 15,000-word MSc in HRM dissertation thesis entitled '*Collective Commonality and Tactical Polyvalence'*, which synthesizes four often overlapping but distinct theories, each learned on the B894 dissertation module and throughout the MSc. The first is Rawl's (1971) theory on the advantages of social union and justice. Secondly, I introduce a model of Spence's (1973) famous theory on signaling, the third is Neo-Weberian State theory (Loewenstein, 1966) and finally, I synthesize with Latour's (2005) much respected theory on the understanding of actor networks. I try to mesh these four theories using a blended approach that utilizes the critical realist lens, Public value theory and Foucauldian poststructuralist authors. Empirically, I construct a two-way fixed effects regression model, using various datasets, both freely available data and UKDS open data. I find that the null of no correlation between a dependent variable welfare expenditure in 2019 and the annual wage index across the OECD for 2025 cannot be rejected. However, the null is rejected when we adjust for welfare protections across the OECD i.e. the relationship or correlation becomes highly significant. I therefore argue and recommend that power relations adapt to contemporary context in a digital age, not just to ensure social security payments for the unemployed can be maintained but that the UK and other OECD member states can enhance their respective economic agendas.

Scope of Research

I will primarily be aiming to use econometric methods and inferential models to advance the gap in the literature I have outlined. The scope relates to robust panel data models of regression using longitudinal datasets that apply to 34 OECD member states. The study of trade unions history from an actor network perspective (i.e. the micro) and their contemporary effects (the macro) are, of course, owed to an interdisciplinary approach. The nature of the research is therefore quantitative (using secondary data) as opposed to the use of primary sources.

Projected 3-Year Research Timeline

I anticipate the length of time to span no further than 36 months (or three years) of FT research.

- 01 – 03 months (3m) – Induction/preparation
- 03 – 06 months (3m) – Econometrics and inferential analysis (via informal learning)
- 06 – 12 months (6m) – Social research methods using data (via informal learning)
- 12 – 18 months (6m) – Data collection and literature review
- 18 – 24 months (6m) – Data analysis and discussion
- 24 – 30 months (6m) – Final write-up, conclusion and introduction
- 30 – 36 months (6m) – Evaluation of findings

Methodological Approach

Secondary data inferential analysis at the state level using a similar two-way fixed effects regression model but with an expanded set of variables (inclusive of GDP growth, infrastructure investment in USD (PPP), inflation and income tax rates across the OECD). This data isn't readily available and may need to be collected and maintained as a tailored 34-country longitudinal dataset, preferably in spreadsheet form. Software requirements will include R, STATA and/or MATLAB as well as Microsoft Office.

END

References

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Spence, M. (1973) 'Job Market Signalling,' *The Quarterly journal of economics*, 87(3), pp. 355–374.